

The Galo's Silent Dawn

In the enchanted springs of Portugal, cobblestone towns sit among terracotta roofs, almond trees that blossom white as snow, and hills crowned with stars. Water is the magic here: every spring, fountain, and old stone well has its own quiet wonder. Enchanted maidens called the Mouras keep the springs sweet, a bright rooster crows only the truth, and a playful little goblin called the Trasgo tidies and teases when no one is looking. Here a hero wins not by being the strongest, but by being kind, asking the water gently, and never giving up on a friend. Even a big, fearsome-looking giant of the hills usually turns out to be lonelier than it is frightening.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause often so everyone can puzzle, wonder, and try ideas. There are no wrong answers here, only new paths to follow.

Before you begin

Barcelos wakes earlier than anywhere, because its rooster wakes it. But on the morning this story begins, the sky over the cobbled square stayed a flat, unbroken grey, and the market stood half-set and uneasy. The Galo de Barcelos, the bright painted rooster who has crowed up every dawn for longer than anyone can remember, sat hunched on his wall with his beak clamped shut. He had lost his crow, and without it the morning simply would not come.

There was worse. The town's pride, the shining silver festival cup, had vanished from its stall in the night, and the market folk, frightened and cross, had fixed the blame on the easiest person: a weary traveller resting at the edge of the square, guilty of nothing but being a stranger on the long road to Santiago. He sat very still, saying little, waiting to be believed.

You looked at the silent rooster, and at the unhappy stranger, and you knew the two troubles were really one. "Let us find the truth," you said, and shouldered your bag.



What is your hero name? Which one or two magics will you carry: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, Riversong, or Birdsong?

Stop 1 The Silent Roost

You climbed to the Galo's wall, and close up he looked truly poorly: feathers dull, head low, his bright comb drooping. He opened his beak to greet you and nothing came out at all, not even a squeak. He could not crow, and so he could not do the one thing he was famous for: crow out the honest truth and clear a wrongly blamed soul. The unfairness of it had taken the heart right out of him.

A bird as proud as the Galo will not be poked or rushed. He needed gentleness, and a reason to lift his head, before his voice would stir.



How do you help the Galo find his heart again? Could Riversong fetch him a sip of cool spring water, could Bloom bring a little colour back to his perch, or could you simply sit with him and promise to set things right? What do you try?

When the Galo felt truly cared for, he managed one small, scratchy cluck, the very first thread of his voice returning. "Bring back the cup," he rasped, "lay it where it belongs, and I will crow so loud the truth cannot be missed."

Stop 2 The Barcelos Market

Down among the stalls, you studied the scene of the mystery. The silver cup's velvet cushion sat empty, but everything around it was strange: no muddy footprints, no forced lock, no sign that any thief had come or gone. A cup does not simply walk away, and yet no person seemed to have carried it off.

Then you began to notice small things. A ribbon gone from one stall. A bright button missing from another. And high above the square, near the top of the old bell tower, something caught the weak light and winked.

★ *If no person took the cup, who did? What sort of creature loves a shiny thing, can carry off ribbons and buttons, and can reach a high stone tower? Follow the little thefts: where do they lead?*

When you laid the clues side by side, they all pointed the same way: up, past the rooftops, to the open top of the old bell tower. You headed for its winding stair.

Stop 3 The Old Bell Tower

The stair climbed and climbed, and you came out breathless among the great bells, with the swifts wheeling and the whole town small below. There, wedged in a snug nest of buttons, ribbons, and bright glass, sat a small jackdaw with a neat grey cap, and there, gleaming in the middle of her treasures, was the silver cup.

She was no thief, of course. She had only done what jackdaws do, gathering what shines to make her nest beautiful, never dreaming of the worry it caused below. She drew the cup close and watched you with one wary, glittering eye, ready to startle at a loud word.

★ *How do you win the shy jackdaw's trust? She will not be grabbed at. Could a gentle voice calm her, could Starlight offer a glint she likes even more, or could you trade her something shiny she may keep? What would please a timid, treasure loving bird?*

When you moved slowly and offered her a fair and shining trade, the jackdaw hopped to one side and let you lift the cup from her hoard. She gave a soft, pleased chirp, as if glad the worry was over too.

Stop 4 The Cup Returned

You carried the silver cup back down into the square and raised it high for all to see. "Here it is," you called. "It was never stolen. A little jackdaw took it up to her nest in the tower, because it shone. There was no thief at all."

A hush fell over the market. One by one, the townsfolk turned to look at the traveller they had been so quick to blame, and their faces filled with shame at their own unfairness. It is a hard thing to face, having wronged a stranger.

★ *How do you help the market folk make it right? What words turn their shame into kindness, and welcome the traveller properly at last?*

When the traveller was welcomed with warm bread, an apology, and a place by the fire, the chill went out of the morning. Only one thing remained undone.

The Dawn Crow

You set the silver cup back on its cushion, exactly where it belonged. The Galo de Barcelos drew himself up tall, his comb bright red again, swelled his chest, and this time, when he opened his beak, out rang a crow so clear and golden it seemed to lift the very sun over the rooftops.

Light poured across the square. The stalls flung open, the bells answered, and the traveller went on his way with a full heart and a fuller bag, blessing the town that had learned to be fair. The Galo crows only the truth, and on this dawn the truth turned out to be a kind one.

You did it together. You were gentle when it was easier to be quick, and you were full of ideas when one idea was not enough. Well done.

The Galo's Silent Dawn: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works (the difficulty bands, the energy stars, helping, twists, all of it). This page has only what is special about this adventure. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map, or sketch it, or lay it out with household objects: a Start, four stops, and a Goal on a winding path. Each player puts a small figure on the Start.
- Each player chooses one or two magics from the five in this world: Bloom, Truth, Starlight, Riversong, or Birdsong. A mix across the players works best.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the things that come up (the silver cup, the jackdaw's shiny nest) from household bits and bricks as you go. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The surprise

Once at each stop the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Surprise
1	A market seller offers you a warm pastel and one free hint.
2	You find a dropped coin that glints: take back one energy star.
3	A cool breeze off the river: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Galo gives an encouraging cluck. All is well; carry on.
5	A passing pilgrim lets you repeat one roll later, whenever you like.
6	A church bell rings the hour and everyone feels brave for one turn.

How it ends

There is no thief in this story and no villain. The "crime" is an innocent mix-up: a shy jackdaw who gathered the shiny cup for her nest, not knowing the trouble it caused. The heart of the adventure is clearing a wrongly blamed stranger and being gentle with the timid jackdaw, so the Galo de Barcelos can crow the truth at dawn. Let the moment when the townsfolk realise their unfairness land softly; the lesson is to be fair and kind, especially to a stranger. See the puzzles page for how to play each stop, and for the solutions.

The Galo's Silent Dawn: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Silent Roost (Easy)

The challenge. The Galo de Barcelos has lost his crow and his spirits. He will not find his voice until the players cheer and care for him.

Intended solutions. A gentle-heart moment more than a magic trick:

- **Riversong** to fetch him a sip of cool spring water and ask the water to soothe his throat.
- **Bloom** to bring a little colour and life back to his drooping perch.
- **Birdsong** to call to him as one bird to another and coax his own song back out.
- A plain kind act with no magic: sitting with him, singing softly, or promising out loud to clear the traveller's name.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have the Galo manage a single weak cluck in answer to any kindness, showing them it is working. Any genuine care brings his voice partway back and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, just stroke the rooster's feathers or say one kind thing, and let that be enough for him to whisper the next clue.

Stop 2: The Barcelos Market (Normal)

The challenge. The silver cup is gone with no thief in sight: no footprints, no broken lock. The players must work out that no person took it, and follow the trail of small shiny thefts (a ribbon, a button, a glint by the tower) upward to the bell tower.

Solution. The clues add up to a creature that loves shiny things and can reach high places, and the glints lead to the top of the **old bell tower**. This is observation and logic, not a magic, though **Starlight** can make a faint glint easier to spot, **Riversong** can ask the square what it saw, and **Birdsong** can ask the market birds which way the shiny little thief flew.

Fallback. If the children are stuck, have a market seller mention "that cheeky bird up the tower has had my buttons again," handing them the link. Reaching the answer with a nudge still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, lay out three shiny clue objects leading in a line toward a tall "tower" (a stack of cups) and ask only "where do the shiny things lead?"

Stop 3: The Old Bell Tower (Normal)

The challenge. The shy jackdaw has the cup in her nest. She loves shiny things and is easily startled. The players must befriend her, not snatch the cup.

Intended solutions. A befriending moment:

- **A fair shiny swap.** Offer her something that shines just as much (a carried trinket, a polished button) to take the cup's place in her nest.
- **A gentle voice.** Speak softly and move slowly so she is not frightened, and she will let you take it.
- **Starlight** to conjure a glint she finds even more delightful, or **Truth** to show her gently that the cup is needed and a swap is fair.
- **Birdsong** to speak to her in her own jackdaw chatter, so she stays calm and comes out instead of taking fright.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have the jackdaw herself nudge a shiny button toward them, as if proposing the trade. The instant they offer any kindness or swap, let her hop aside and release the cup.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, a single shiny swap is plenty; the jackdaw is timid but easily pleased.

Stop 4: The Cup Returned (Easy)

The challenge. The players return the cup and, harder, help the townsfolk undo their unfairness and welcome the wrongly blamed traveller.

Intended solution. Have the players show the cup and explain there was no thief, then say something that turns the crowd's shame into kindness: an invitation, a shared loaf, a warm welcome for the traveller. There is no roll to fail. **Truth** fits naturally here, but plain kind words work.

Fallback. If a child is unsure what to say, have the traveller smile and offer forgiveness first, making it easy for the townsfolk to follow. The success is guaranteed; this stop is about the warm feeling of fairness restored.

Make it simpler. For a younger child, simply handing the traveller a piece of bread and saying sorry together is the whole of it.

The Dawn Crow (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. The cup goes back on its cushion, the Galo de Barcelos crows at last, and the sun rises over Barcelos. Let the children feel the market wake and the traveller leave happy. They won by being gentle with the jackdaw and fair to a stranger, which is the only way anyone wins among the Enchanted Springs.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.